



Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship

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4 February 2022

Alan Shepard, PhD
President and Vice-Chancellor
Western University
Stevenson Hall, Suite 2107
London, ON N6A 5B8

Dear President Shepard:

I am writing as president of the Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS), an organization of university faculty members and others dedicated to the defense of academic freedom and the merit principle in higher education. (For further information, see our website at www.safs.ca.)

SAFS commends Western University for stating publicly that “individual faculty members have the freedom to express their opinions and beliefs.” Western professors and others had urged Western to violate the academic freedom of Donald Welsh, a professor of physiology at the Schulich School of Medicine and Dentistry, and to its credit Western rejected these appeals.

Western has demonstrated that it understands that academic freedom is essential to the mission of the university, for it enables new ideas to be spoken and to be debated robustly. Those who disagree with Dr Welsh are free to criticize his views and defend their own. In the absence of academic

freedom, the public could not trust what academics say, as people would be suspicious that their research was guided by the need to come to approved conclusions.

We respectfully ask you to respond to our letter. With your permission, we will post your response along with this letter on our website.

Sincerely,

Mark Mercer, PhD

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